Start with the right spot

Before you reach for the spade, spend a little time looking. Sunlight, water and access will shape this garden for years; moving a few pegs now is easier than moving the whole plot later.



Start with a patch you can look after. Leave room for the garden to grow later.

Sunlight comes first

Look for at least half a day of direct sun, preferably more. Check the shadows in spring as well as summer: a low wall may shade the soil just when you want it to warm up. Avoid planting beneath trees or beside a large hedge, where roots compete for water as well as light.

Look below the surface

Visit after rain and notice where water stands. On unfamiliar ground, dig a few small holes and inspect the soil for rubble and compacted soil before choosing dig or no-dig. In a new build home, for example, look first for buried building debris. A covering of compost would not make that debris disappear - it would have to be removed.

Put it within easy reach

Check that your hose reaches, or plan rainwater storage nearby. You need a convenient route for a loaded wheelbarrow and regular trips from the kitchen. A slightly imperfect patch that you visit every day may be more useful than a remote corner you keep forgetting.

How much ground?

Begin with one bed and grow what you like eating. If you manage that comfortably, add another. Salads and regularly picked crops suit a small start; a winter's supply of potatoes needs more space. There is no single plot size that feeds every household, and taking on too much ground is a very quick way to lose the enjoyment.

John: Starting on New Ground; Sophia's Garden; Food Independence; Could I Feed Myself?